

Syllabus

Advanced Language Arts Seminar

This course introduces advanced high school students to the craft of literary studies at the college level. Through close reading of challenging texts, students learn to form their own critical interpretation, to write and speak with sophistication, and to build well-crafted arguments one piece of evidence, one claim, and one draft at a time. Over the course of the year, students polish their style, grammar, and vocabulary as they produce creative texts, and develop the research skills integral to successful academic writing and public speaking.

The goal of AoPS Academy Language Arts courses is to train the intellectual leaders of the next generation by fostering creative problem solving. In our classes, students tackle projects that are framed as interpretation and communication problems: how can we communicate an idea in just the right way? Or, how can we understand complex ideas that are being communicated to us? To solve these problems, students must craft written pieces and oral presentations that demonstrate mastery of the Language Arts skills they learned in class. In this way, our courses help students develop the confidence and advanced literacy skills they need to solve any communication problem they encounter, whether it's in college, in the professional world, or in their own lives.

Time Commitment: This 36-week course includes 105 minutes of in-class instruction and 60-90 minutes of homework each week, corresponding to a full-year course.

Exams: Students take three in-class exams, one at the end of each trimester. Exams focus on the analysis and writing skills students are learning in class.

Homework: Students should expect to spend about 1-2 hours on homework every week. Homework will include: practicing skills learned in class through questions in the course homepage, long-term writing assignments connected to the unit project, and assigned reading in one of the three trimesterly textbooks.

Content:

Week	Topic
1	Introduction to Literary Analysis
2	Food for Thought
3	Narrator and Narrative
4	Remix
5	Fairy Tales
6	More Fairy Tales
7	Symbolism and Poetry
8	Literary Analysis in Writing
9	Workshop
10	Revision
11	Sentences
12	Exam 1
13	Argue
14	Listen
15	Respond
16	Play Fair
17	Debate
18	Audience

Week	Topic
19	Nemesis
20	Stakes and Research
21	Workshop
22	Revise
23	Refine
24	Exam 2
25	Telling the Truth in Personal Narrative
26	Character
27	Dialogue
28	Setting
29	Plot Structure
30	What You Don't Say
31	Tone and Mood
32	What the Reader Takes Away
33	Workshop
34	Voice and Revision
35	Polishing and Editing
36	Exam 3

The course is divided into three units, each twelve weeks long:

Unit	Description	Common Core Standards	Core Skills or Concepts
1 Literary Analysis	Students learn and practice rhetorical analysis by studying several literary pieces. The unit culminates in students writing a literary analysis essay. Book: <i>The Best American Stories of the Century; How to Read Literature Like a Professor</i>	RL 9-10.1, 9-10.2, 9-10.3, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.9, 9-10.10 W 9-10.1A, 9-10.1B, 9-10.1D, 9-10.1E, 9-10.2A, 9-10.2B, 9-10.2C SL 9-10.2, 9-10.4 L 9-10.1B, 9-10.2A, 9-10.3, 9-10.4	Literary analysis; narration; literary influence; symbolism; versification and scansion; close reading; creative writing; pre-writing skills; revision techniques, crafting sentences
2 Argumentative Writing	Students will analyze several challenging nonfiction texts to learn about the components of argumentation. They showcase their understanding of effective argumentation by writing an argumentative essay. Book: <i>They Say/I Say; Little Norton Reader</i>	RI 9-10.1, 9-10.2, 9-10.6, 9-10.9 W 9-10.1A, 9-10.1B, 9-10.1, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.8, 9-10.9B SL 9-10.1A, 9-10.1B, 9-10.1C, 9-10.3 L 9-10.4D, 9-10.5A, 9-10.5B, 9-10.6	Elements of a debate; analyzing and crafting counterarguments; argument types (ethos, logos, pathos); how to avoid logical fallacies; understanding your audience in argumentation; principles of academic research; using strategic language as an augmentation strategy; revision techniques.
3 Memoir Writing	Students turn the lens on themselves, using the analytical and writing skills they've been developing to write their own short memoirs while examining several published memoirs. Book: <i>Little Norton Reader</i>	RL 9-10.2, 9-10.3, 9-10.4, 9-10.10 W 9-10.3A, 9-10.3B, 9-10.3C, 9-10.3E, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.10 SL 9-10.1C, 9-10.4, 9-10.6 L 9-10.3, 9-10.5A, B, 9-10.6	Writing memoirs; understanding personal narratives; static, round, flat, and dynamic characterization; reading and crafting effective dialogue; understanding temporal, physical, and vague/vivid settings; plot structure, tone, voice, and mood as literary devices; creative writing; copy editing.

To interpret the Common Core Standards column on the table above, visit the Common Core ELA website at www.corestandards.org/ELA-Literacy.